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**The Philosophy of
LAND-GIFT
MISSION**

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BY

VIMALA THAKAR

**Sarvodaya Prachuralayam
TANJORE ★ INDIA**

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SARVODAYA PRACHURALAYAM

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PUBLISHER'S NOTE

This brochure presents an address on the fundamental principles and philosophy behind the Land-Gift (Bhoodan) Mission of Acharya Vinoba Bhave by Sri. Vimala Thakar at the Garthnewydd Community House, Cheltenham in South Wales on 22nd August during her European tour in 1959. This was kindly sent to us by Mr. David Hoggett of the Community House for publication in "Sarvodaya". But it was felt that it would be more useful as a brochure.

Sri. Vimala Thakar has been spiritually inclined even from her childhood. She is a student of philosophy of Nagpur University and she was naturally attracted by the spiritual appeal of the Bhoodan Movement. She has been taking a leading part in propagating the movement throughout the country with her yatras and inspiring talks. Her personal appeal to individuals for a change of heart through Bhoodan and the revelation of the innate goodness in Man is narrated in the address with her own thrilling experiences.

The publication of this brochure happens to accidentally coincide with the publication of her letter and the series of articles in the "Bhoodan" in which she has expressed the present working of her mind for seeking the 'Something beyond' with a personal revolution in the individual and for meeting "the challenge of the mind in freeing it from the conditionings" as beautifully expressed by J. Krisnamurthi. Though sister Vimala Thakar will not be able to actually work in the physical field of the Bhoodan movement with the thousands of her co-workers her spiritual contribution from a different plane will be more valuable to give a new impetus to this great moral revolution.

Tanjore,
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Sarvodaya Pracharini.

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FRIENDS, as I am sitting with you in this room this evening, I am reminded of a hymn from the Upanishads. The poet compares human life to a powerful river current. As pieces of wood are brought together by a powerful current, go on floating together for a time, and are then thrown apart again, even so the powerful current of human life brings us together, keeps us together for a while, and again thrusts us apart.

When I left India four months back, I had no idea that I would come to England. I was in Yugoslavia as a member of a study group, sent by Vinoba, to study the agricultural co-operatives and workers, management of industries there. Friends in Scandinavia invited me, and I went there. Then some of my friends in England invited me, and I found myself here.

I am going to share with you to-day the fundamental principles behind the Land Gift Mission of Vinoba Bhave. It is necessary to go into the background—political, social, and economic—of the movement. We will have to go back to 1915, when Mahatma Gandhi returned to India from South Africa. He was the first man

to tell the Indian people that eliminating the British Raj from India was only the negative aspect of independence. Its positive aspect was to discover the basic principles on which the Indian people should build up their life. He told us in 1917 that ending the British rule was not very difficult.

“But what are you going to do after that? Are you going to follow the West so far as industrialisation is concerned? What are you going to do about your agriculture? and your social order?”

People used to laugh at him and say, “Let us first win independence, and then we will think about these things.” But Mahatma Gandhi was a farsighted person. He travelled up and down the country for nearly one year, and after that came to the conclusion that India would have to remain an agricultural country, and evolve an agro-centred economic plan and a new pattern of industrialisation for its 550,000 villages.

He presented an eighteen-point constructive programme, including the re-distribution of land, village industries, a new scheme of education, which is known all over India as Basic Education, the elimination of the abuses of caste, equality of the sexes, and so on. He was visualising an

independent India without class or caste, an India based on the principles of equality, love and nonviolence.

We became free in 1947, but we lost him in 1948, and he had no chance during his lifetime to work out the whole scheme. We were standing at the crossroads and did not know where to go.

It was in 1950 in Hyderabad State, that the poor people became impatient. They were thinking that with independence a new era would be ushered in, and there would be no poverty. But they found on the one hand that poverty was increasing, and that on the other hand the wealthy were getting richer. And there were riots. The poor started robbing the rich, burning their houses, killing and plundering and the rest of it.

Vinoba comes into the picture now. He is an old man today of sixty-five years of age, old according to the Indian conception of life. He is a person who has spent many years in solitude, working on the land, and studying languages and different religions.

When he heard about these riots in Hyderabad State, he felt that they were a challenge to nonviolence, and so he walked into the district. He asked the people, "What are you doing?."

After having won independence through non-violence, this violence does not make any sense. If you want to change your social order, you can do it through nonviolence and love”.

And the people said, “We don’t want to kill the rich people; we are not butchers; we don’t want to slaughter them. But we work on the land, and still our children are hungry. We work at the loom for eight hours out of twenty-four every day, but our children are naked. What we want is food, clothing, shelter. We are not beggars. Give us land, and we will till it and earn our living honestly”.

Vinoba said that he realised very well that so long as there are seeds of conflict and violence in the social order, you cannot have a nonviolent society just by preaching nonviolence and love, peace and brotherhood. He turned to the land-owners and said, “We are a free nation. But freedom has no meaning if men are divided. If there are starving millions in India you cannot have a real democracy. You have given these people the right to vote, and you should also give them the right to live. Let them have the means to eat. Will you, therefore, share the land you have in this village with these people? After all, land is created by God. When you die you

cannot take land with you. Land, air, sunlight, water, are all gifts of God. So let us share our land”.

It is difficult to describe the deep impact that these simple truths have on the Indian people. When Vinoba started explaining the philosophy of sharing, and love in action, in these simple terms, it had an amazing effect. A person stood up and said, “I want to donate a hundred acres”.

A hundred acres of land were distributed among the poor people of that village,—and Vinoba started thinking furiously. “What has happened? I asked for land and I received it, within one hour. Not one acre, not ten acres, but one hundred acres. Does God want me to proceed with this? Perhaps I can be an instrument in helping the landless agriculturists in rural India”.

The next day he announced that he would not go back to his ashram near Wardha. He had decided to walk through the whole of India, explaining the philosophy of sharing and love to the people, and persuade them to share their land. I can remember how the people in towns and cities started by laughing and jeering at Vinoba, but within two months he has received twelve thousand acres of land, just by persuading the people to share it. And within one year he had received 500,000 acres in the United Provinces.

The Indian National Congress came to the conclusion that this was not just begging for land, but that Vinoba's method contained the seed of social change. By the end of 1952 Congress was helping him directly. And then came Jayaprakash Narayan, the founder of the Socialist movement in India. He saw that Vinoba was not only collecting and re-distributing land, but was trying to change the *attitude* towards private property and ownership. He joined the movement at the beginning of 1953, and with him came the moral support of the Socialist Party in India. By the end of 1954 Vinoba had received more than two million acres of land, and hundreds of youths were walking through the villages carrying the message of Land Gift Mission. Rich and poor alike were co-operating in this movement. People in India had not seen or heard of anything like this before. Social and economic change through the co-operation of rich and poor and without class conflict was something novel, unheard of, unprecedented in history.

And then, after receiving two million acres of land, Vinoba said, "Let us take the next step. With your small individual pieces of land, you are not going to increase production. Why not pool your resources, work together, and vest the ownership of the land in the village community?"

Land does not belong to man, but is a gift from God, so let the village community be the trustees of it. Let all the people residing in the village become one family. Those who want to go in for agriculture can till the land. Let those who want to go in for handicrafts and village industries be provided with the necessary instruments. Let those who are interested in education shoulder the responsibilities of educating the children in the villages according to the Basic Education scheme.”

And that is how the Gramdan movement started. ‘Gram’ is a Sanskrit word meaning ‘village’, and ‘dan’ is another Sanskrit word meaning ‘voluntary surrender of ownership’. There are about four thousand villages to-day where the landowners have surrendered their individual ownership, and where ownership of the land vests in the village community. After taking this step all the villagers assemble and decide what to do with the land. Usually they re-distribute it among themselves, with the condition that no one will be able to sell or mortgage it, or to fragment it further. They may decide that they will re-distribute the land once every ten years. In this case the land is given to families for tilling, and they take the produce; but as far as selling the surplus goods, or purchasing seeds, fertilizers, bullocks or ploughs is

concerned, they act co-operatively. It is a sort of synthesis of village ownership, co-operation in agricultural work, and family farming.

Thus Vinoba started by requesting people to share their land with the landless, and then, in 1955, took this further step of asking the people not only to share part of their land but to surrender their individual ownership completely, and vest it in the village community.

I can tell you about my personal experience in Assam, where about two hundred villages have joined this movement. I am working in one of the districts, North Lakhimpur, to the north of the river Brahmaputra, near the Himalayas, where there are forty-five villages in a contiguous area in which each landowner has surrendered his individual ownership.

Seven of these villages have undertaken collective farming. They did not want to re-distribute the land to individuals, but wanted to try farming collectively, as well as building huts and roads, they have doubled the production from the land.

There are other villages where people have re-distributed the land according to the land/man ratio. This varies according to the quality of the land. If it is fertile and irrigated even one and

a half acres may be enough for a family of five in India. If it is dry they need sometimes ten acres, sometimes fifteen acres, even twenty-five acres for such a family.

In every Gramdan village they have an assembly. Every family sends two representatives—one woman, one man. There is, however, only one vote per family. The village assembly then appoints different committees—for agriculture, industry, education. These village assemblies send their representatives to the Government-appointed ‘Gram Panchayat’, the Council of Elders. They become co-opted members of this Panchayat appointed by the district Government.

The part of industries in such development also needs mention. Generally, people think that Gandhi and Vinoba are against industrialisation and mechanization. I would like to share with you my own experience. Neither was Gandhi, nor is Vinoba, against machines, mechanization or science. But we are 380,000,000 people in India, and we have an abundance of surplus human labour. We therefore have to evolve a pattern of industrialization which is labour-intensive rather than capital-intensive. We have to use all the human labour that is available in the Indian village, and we will need machines—small scale ones—to supplement human labour.

We do not need to go in for large scale production or big industries so far as food and clothing are concerned, because the raw materials are there in every village. Let that raw material be turned into finished products through the utilization of the human labour that is available in the village, supplementing it by machines. We cannot judge whether this sort of experiment has been successful or not, because we have only just started. But I feel that not only for India but for the whole of Asia, where there is such a wealth of human labour, it is incumbent upon us to evolve a new pattern of industrialization.

We are trying to get new machines, small agricultural implements, and so on; and I have been thinking about how to utilize electricity for handicrafts, because we have to increase the purchasing power of the Indian people in a very short time. Such is the part that the machine has to play in our villages.

But we need cars, bicycles, fountain pens, wrist watches and so on, and these things cannot be produced in a decentralized way in India to-day. For these big or heavy industries Vinoba visualises social ownership.

We have not yet started to apply these Sarvodaya values to industrial life, because the

development of India means firstly the development of its 550,000 villages. In this revolution of social change it is not the towns and cities that are going to lead, but the villages. It is the agriculturalist who is going to lead, and towns and cities will have to play a supplementary role. Those people in towns and cities who have money can help the villages with contributions for digging wells, for providing agricultural implements, and for paying off the old debts of the peasants.

Besides the rich merchants and businessmen, the Government has also been helping us. In nearly every state the Government has passed Bhoodan laws enabling Vinoba and his companions to distribute the land with legal sanction. When we redistribute the land, or when we constitute a village assembly, the Government officers accompany us. When we transfer the land they transfer its title to the new owners. The Government gives a loan to Gramdan villages free of interest, for credit societies, co-operative societies and for paying off old debts. In such ways as these the Government has been helping.

Naturally the question arises as to the attitude of the political parties. I mentioned that Congress and the socialist party have given us their moral support, and individual members have been

working with us. I should mention that Communists too have been helping us, not as party members but as individuals. Last December I was in Kerala, and the then Chief Minister, Mr. Namboodripad, accompanied me to some districts. At one of the meetings he said "Where we Communists have failed Vinoba has succeeded. We have been regarding the peasant as a reactionary person, but Vinoba has succeeded in changing his attitude towards private property and ownership. He has influenced the people to such an extent that in thousands of villages they have surrendered their individual ownership, without compulsion and without legislation. This is a movement we want to help." Mr. Namboodripad and his Government have played an important part in the reconstruction activities of the Gramdan villages of Kerala.

There is another thing that Vinoba asks the villagers to do, for maintaining the solidarity of their village community. In 1957 we had a general election, and representatives of about 50 Gramdan villages approached Vinoba and said, "We have joined this movement ; we are building new roads, damming the rivers, and trying to reconstruct the whole of our village life. But, Vinobaji, the party candidates, canvassers, and those who are busy with election propaganda are sure to come to our villages, and there is a

possibility of a split being created in our village life. What should we do?" Vinoba replied, "Every village should write a letter to each party leader, saying that it has no time for separate meetings, one for the candidate of the Indian National Congress, another for the candidate of the Praja Socialist party, yet another for the candidate of the Communist party, and so forth. The parties should decide amongst themselves when they want to visit the village and there should be a meeting in which all the candidates will have to speak from the same platform. It will save their time and their energy, —and it will save the country's money. Let them come to your village, and ask them to speak with restraint, pointing out that every member of the village community is sitting before them, including the children and young people. Ask them not to abuse each other, or try to undermine the good work that every party has done. After all, the parties exist to serve us. They are not ends in themselves, but means to a certain end. Let them speak, and afterwards arrange a feast for them. Let them sit side by side. Tell them that it is necessary to introduce sportsmanship into political life. As long as there are different parties, they should co-operate with one another in creating healthy traditions. So let them come together in this way."

I may mention that the relations between the workers of different political parties in India are not sweet. They are very strained. They are based on mutual suspicion and bitterness, hatred and jealousy, and Vinoba wants the people to enter political life in a spirit of co-operation and love. He visualises a society in which there will be no conflict of interest among the citizens, because, all will be producers, sharing work, sharing leisure, and sharing the fruits of their work. He feels that if we are successful in eliminating this conflict of interest, and eliminating casteism from social life, political parties (which today partly exist to represent these different interests) may become unnecessary. With the evolution of a society based on mutual love and co-operation, on trust and equality, the necessity of having different political parties may be lessened.

This is not just a movement for collecting pieces of land and distributing them. It is a movement that aims at creating a sounder foundation for democracy. Vinoba feels that a real democracy can exist only on a spiritual basis. And by that he means faith in the innate goodness of human beings. To-day we do not have that faith. We talk of brotherhood, we talk of peace, we talk of love, but we do not know what love in action is, except in our families. In the family

every relationship is based on love in action, but when we step out of family life our relationships are not based on trust and love and co-operation.

It may not be out of place to relate to you at this stage an inspiring incident that happened recently. It was in a small village that, one afternoon, Vinoba was resting. We had all gone out for our afternoon meals to the village. A person entered Vinoba's room. He had a dagger in his hand, and wanted to kill Vinoba. (For there are reactionary forces in Indian society, who have vested interests in the present social order and who do not want Vinoba's movement to succeed.) He said to Vinoba, "Open your eyes. If you go on distributing land to the poor people, and telling them that land belongs not to man, but to God, and that everyone has a right to the land, it will be very difficult for us to live. Poverty was created by God to give rich people an opportunity for charity." (This is an idea prevalent among some orthodox Hindus, and in some religious books too.) So he said, "Open your eyes. Look what I have got for you." Vinoba opened his eyes, saw the dagger, and with his face wreathed in smiles, said, "The Lord has come to take away what he gave to me." I do not know what passed through that smile,

but the dagger dropped to the ground, and the fellow started running back. Vinoba sat up, tears running down his cheeks, and he said, "The Lord had come to take away what he had given me, but he found that I was not ready, so he is going away again."

You may say that this makes no sense, that it is just God-intoxication, but that is the sort of person Vinoba is. He is a person of tremendous faith,—and he shares that faith in the goodness of human nature with all of us. We are four thousand workers with him, and most of us had no experience of working in any movement before. We were utter strangers to the Indian public. I, for example, had not worked in any movement in my life: I was straight from University and was not known in any of the provinces. I went and joined him because I felt that through him democracy was getting a spiritual basis, a sure foundation.

I was walking through Gaya district in Bihar one day, and the people there had told us of a land-owner with five hundred acres of land who drank too much: an evil person. They taunted us, "If you have faith in God, go and try to convert him." The half a dozen companions with me said, "Vimala Behn, we shouldn't go." I replied, "Go we must. This is not only a

challenge to our faith in God : it is a challenge to His grace. Why have we given the right to vote to that person if we have no faith that he can be converted? If we have no faith in his goodness, we should not give him the right to vote." For universal franchise becomes meaningless if we have no faith in human goodness, whether we call it God residing in the heart of human beings, or whether we call it man's innate goodness. My companions were unwilling to accompany me. So I went alone, and knocked at his door. The door opened, and a middle-aged man asked, "What brings you here? Haven't the villagers told you what sort of person I am?" "Yes, they have. But they have not told me, and you do not realise, that you are my brother." He was taken aback. People either used to shun him with revulsion, or they were afraid of him. None had called him 'brother' with the whole being, with the spontaneity of love. I don't know exactly what was going on within me, but I said, "You are my brother. The same God created us both. And I am quite safe with you, for I bring you the message of a saint. Won't you allow me to enter?" He put his palms together in the Indian fashion and said, "Yes sister. Please come in." There were tears in his eyes. I had a link talk with him. He gave me 125 acres

out of 500 acres. He invited other villagers, and within four hours I had received more than 225 acres of land. I went back to my companions and said, "Vinoba shares his faith in human nature with all of us." We are not saints or yogis; we are just normal human beings. But Vinoba feels that the time has come to apply spiritual values in day to day life and to our daily problems. The time has come to realise that love can become a motive force for social change. Faith in human nature can create a new dimension in the technique of social transformation. But there are hundreds of stories like this. Such incidents have taken place not only in my life. I am only one insignificant worker in the movement of a great saint of India.

Has not the time come to apply our faith in the existence of God, our faith in love and co-operation, not only in India, but in the West too? Has not the time come to apply these values in social, economic, and political life? We ourselves feel that there is no other alternative to the war that is threatening. If we really want a peaceful society and a peaceful world, cannot we make a new start with these values as our real strength?

We, in an agrarian context, are trying to apply those values in our own way. The industrialised West will have to evolve different methods and techniques for translating those values into practical life. If there is any message from Vinoba and the Land Gift Mission to the Western world, I think it lies in the bold attempt to translate his faith in the existence of God and human love into our individual and social life.

If we think it is too difficult to change the social and economic order in this way, if it is too big, then let us start with our own individual lives. Individual conduct can introduce a new dimension. In this technique of social change Gandhi was alone when he started. Vinoba was alone when he started.

I do not want to take more of your time. It has been a privilege for me to share my thoughts with you. I came down here to spend a couple of days with my friends, and to find out what they are doing here. They have been kind enough to arrange this meeting, and I am very grateful to them, — and also to all of you.



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A Monthly Digest running its eleventh year is endeavouring to present within its small compass the Sarvodaya ideology of Mahatma Gandhi—The Welfare of All based on Ruskin's "*Unto This Last*", with special reference to its application in action to the socio-economic life through the Bhoodan Gramdan movement of Acharya Vinoba during the last ten years and similar trends of thought and allied movements in other parts of the world with the Sarvodaya values upholding the sanctity of life and freedom of man and for the peace of the world.

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